



Social Psychology (SOCPSY)

Module 5: Helping and Attraction

Prosocial Behaviour and the Bystander Effect

Lesson Notes

KMVTECHUG

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Prosocial Behaviour

Prosocial behaviour is any action intended to benefit others: helping, sharing, donating, or volunteering. Social psychology asks both why people help and why they sometimes fail to help even when they could.

The Bystander Effect

The bystander effect is the finding that the more witnesses present, the less likely any one person is to help. Diffusion of responsibility is the belief that someone else will help. Pluralistic ignorance is assuming there is no emergency because others look calm.

Campus example: a student collapses near a crowded notice board and many people walk past, each assuming someone else has already called for help.

Why People Help

Motives include kin selection, reciprocal altruism, and empathy-altruism. Helping rises when the emergency is clear, the helper feels responsible, and the cost is not overwhelming.

Reflect: *If you saw someone collapse on campus, what would make you more likely to act rather than wait for others?*

Closing

Understanding bystander processes can increase the chance of real help. The next lesson covers attraction.